

# In the Boondocks

**With hopes of using its leverage with the UPA Government to expand its base dashed, the Left has to carry the baggage of its new-found allies and principles**

■ By Shafi Rahman

Last Tuesday, Prakash Karat hoped, would end with a bang. Instead, it ended with a whimper, leaving the CPI(M) general secretary and fellow travellers of the Left shaking their heads in disbelief. That was not how the comrades had expected things to unfold when Karat made his first trip to the inner sanctum of heartland politics just a week ago in pursuit of his aim to bring the Congress-led UPA Government to its knees.

When Karat befriended Dalit diva Mayawati before a posse of cameras, the photographs that emerged carried hope. Caught in a rather indecorous task of explaining the Left's mixing its brand of class politics with Mayawati's politics of caste determination, Karat after his foray into realpolitik noted: "Mayawati reiterated her opposition to the deal. It was decided that there should be a cooperation to stop the deal and hence a struggle against the UPA Government in this regard."

Worse, his appetite for stiff ideological

will be doomed on July 22," Karat declared.

But as Parliament convened for the two-day session, it was trouble for the Left from the word go. Speaker Somnath Chatterjee cocked a snook at his party colleagues by declining to step down, presumably in retaliation to the CPI(M)'s brazenness which saw the veteran Marxist's name being included in the list of CPI(M) MPs withdrawing support to the UPA Government.

Its rows not exactly overflowing with orators, the party deployed Mohammed Salim whose lung power often makes up for lack of logic—or even grace. When he brushed aside Congress President Sonia Gandhi's acknowledgement of the Left's four-and-half years of support by saying "we don't want your certificate", he met with jibes from the members of the Samajwadi Party (SP) and Congress who shouted "*Ab Mayawati se le lo*".

The Left's decision to vote along with the BJP is also giving it some uncomfortable moments. Though the Left plans to make use of the anti-America feeling within the Muslim community in

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confrontation which led to the snapping of ties with the UPA Government has deprived the party of the key role it once enjoyed as a national player. Now his hopes rest on the on-again-off-again Third Alternative. So he kept himself busy the whole week talking to the Telugu Desam Party (TDP), the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha, the Janata Dal (Secular), the Telangana Rashtra Samiti (TRS) and the National Conference (NC). As his Operation Topple Manmohan progressed, the desperation got into his nerves. "We wish to warn the Congress-led UPA Government that in case you lose the trust vote, do not try and push the Indo-US nuclear deal. The country will revolt. The deal is doomed and the Government

its bastions to its advantage in the Lok Sabha elections, Muslim parties like the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) and NC have come out against the Left's sweeping assertions about the community. NC's Omar Abdullah, whom Karat met in an attempt to persuade him to vote against the UPA, taunted the leftists in his speech in the Lok Sabha. "I am a Muslim and I am an Indian. And I see no distinction between the two. I don't know why I should fear the nuclear deal. It is a deal between two countries which, I hope, will become equals in the future," said Abdullah, adding, "The enemies of Indian Muslims are not America or deals like these. The enemies are the same as the enemies of all those who are poor—